ILLICIT SUBSTANCES



Substance use is associated with increased postoperative complications, prolonged hospital length of stay, and increased healthcare costs. [1-4] Acute intoxication and chronic use have implications for perioperative care. [5]

Additional challenges depend on the severity and type of substance(s) used, as well as other factors that may be associated with substance use, including experiencing homelessness or mental illness. Collaboration with community providers is important, especially for patients being treated for opioid use disorder.

Screening Tools

Screening Questions:

- In the last 12 months, have you used drugs other than those required for medical reasons? (not including alcohol or cannabis)
- If yes, characterize drug use (drug, dose, frequency, and route of administration)

The Drug Abuse Screening Test (DAST-10) is a validated 10-item brief screening tool that assesses drug use (excluding alcohol and tobacco), in the past 12 months and gives a score of the degree of problems related to drug use and misuse. [6,7] This allows preoperative interventions to target those patients with substantial or severe problems related to drug abuse.

Drug Abuse Screening Test (DAST-10)

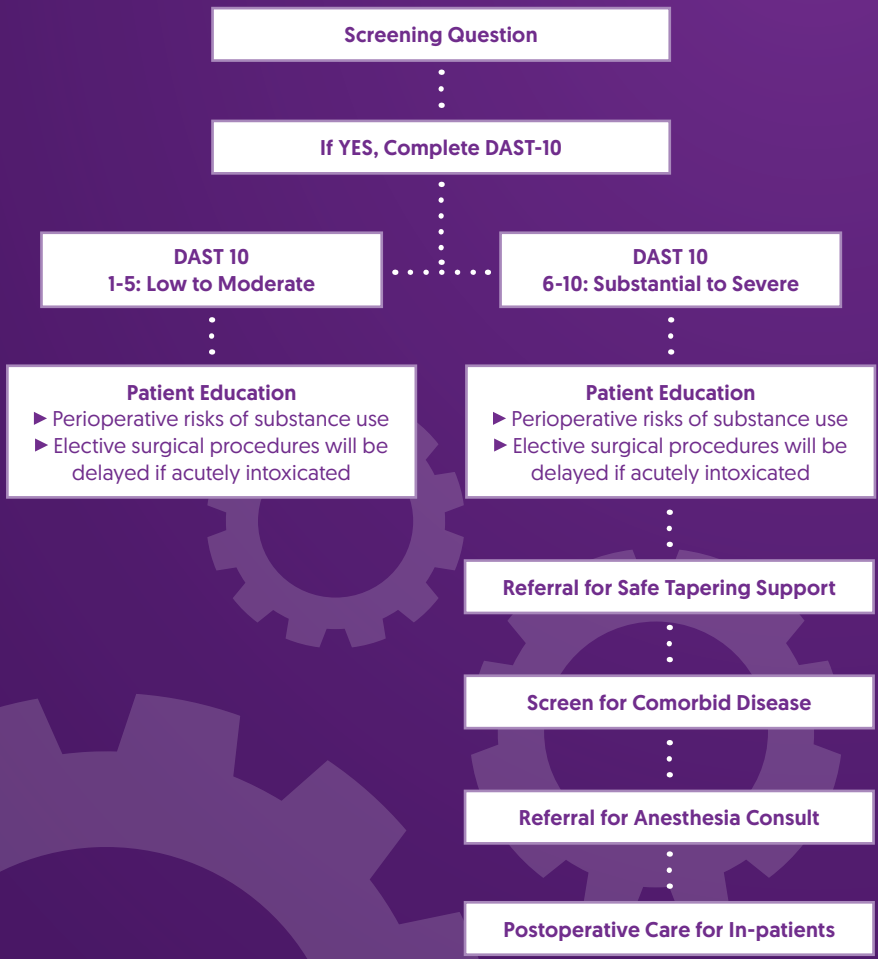
These questions refer to drug use in the past 12 months.
Please answer Yes or No.

	YES	NO
1. Have you used drugs other than those required for medical reasons?	☐	☐
2. Do you use more than one drug at a time?	☐	☐
3. Are you always able to stop using drugs when you want to?	☐	☐
4. Have you had "blackouts" or "flashbacks" as a result of drug use?	☐	☐
5. Do you ever feel bad or guilty about your drug use?	☐	☐
6. Does your spouse (or parents) ever complain about your involvement with drugs?	☐	☐
7. Have you neglected your family because of your use of drugs?	☐	☐
8. Have you engaged in illegal activities in order to obtain drugs?	☐	☐
9. Have you ever experienced withdrawal symptoms (felt sick) when you stopped taking drugs?	☐	☐
10. Have you had medical problems as a result of your drug use (e.g., memory loss, hepatitis, convulsions, bleeding, etc.)?	☐	☐

SCORING Score 1 point for each question answered **YES**
Except for question 3 for which a **NO** receives 1 point.

Skinner HA (1982). The Drug Abuse Screening Test. Addictive Behavior. 7(4):363-371.
Yudko E, Lozhkina O, Fouts A (2007). A comprehensive review of the psychometric properties of the Drug Abuse Screening Test. J Subst Abuse Treatment. 32:189-198.

SUBSTANCE USE · ILLICIT SUBSTANCES ALGORITHM



Prehabilitation and Optimization Recommendations

Patient Education	⚙ Advise patients on the perioperative risks of substance use [8] ⚙ Advise patients that elective surgical procedures will be delayed if they are acutely intoxicated [8] ⚙ Recommend support services: • Encourage patients to see their healthcare provider for safe ways to decrease substance use before surgery • Online services: available at Help Starts Here • Telephone service: 24-hour BC Alcohol and Drug Information and Referral Service toll-free from anywhere in B.C. at 1-800-663-1441
Referral for Safe Tapering Support	⚙ Addiction Medicine or Primary Care with/without RACE line support
Screen for Comorbid Disease	⚙ CBC ⚙ EKG ⚙ HIV ⚙ Hep B ⚙ Hep C

Prehabilitation and Optimization Recommendations

Referral for Anesthesia Consult	To develop effective pain management strategies and explore options for anesthesia and postoperative pain control, especially in moderate to severely invasive surgery
Postoperative Care for Inpatients	Referral to Addiction Medicine consultative services to avoid complicated withdrawal and facilitate discharge planning and supports